

Cover to *Iron Man (2005) #17* by Gerald Parel.

Stark Tower. In this movie, we designed a language where the suits can, upon command, come to him. Now, it doesn't always happen exactly as Tony Stark plans it, which is part of the fun. But the A.I. is there; he's designed it so the suits can come to him in a situation when needed.

"We've never seen multiples of these suits before, and now we have a phenomenal 22-minute sequence that completely rocks. We're able to show on display all the artificial intelligence that Tony Stark created, in a pretty phenomenal way. That's very exciting."

One thing everyone involved with *Iron Man 3* agrees on: The character of Tony Stark is constantly changing.

"He's always a work in progress," Broussard says. "He's imperfect, which is what makes him so interesting. You can't ever have a character that stays stagnant—they have to continually be growing.

"This is essentially the fourth chapter in Tony Stark's story on screen. How do you keep it interesting? How do you keep him growing, changing, giving him new challenges? Knowing that it probably won't be his last onscreen adventure, so you can't just dust your hands and say, 'Well, that was Tony Stark's story, kids.'"

D'Esposito adds: "*In Iron Man 1*, Tony's faced with a dilemma where he's in a cave, and he has to save his life and really think about his purpose. In *Iron Man 2*, he's fighting demons, he thinks he's dying, and it's maybe a little bit narcissistic. In *Avengers*, he really makes a sacrifice play and sacrifices his own life for the good of mankind. I think all those experiences lead up to *Iron Man 3*. He's certainly a more developed person."

Black adds: "The way to go about doing a part three, if you're ever in that position—as I'm lucky enough to be—is to find a way that the first two weren't done yet. You have to find a way to make sure that the story that's emerging is still ongoing and, by the time you've finished number three, will be something resembling the culmination of a trilogy. I think we've really found ways to make this feel organic and new, based on what's come before, and that's what I'm happy about."

And that's Tony Stark all over: a mixture of new and old, high-tech and low. Champagne brunches on the Riviera, followed by long nights sweating over a welding torch in a rural tool shed.

The penthouse and the cave.

Broussard sums up the series: "It's gotta keep going in ways that feel like you're doing something new and cool, without spinning your wheels. That's always the challenge of a part three, or a part four, depending on how you look at it. And we're always up for a challenge."